

Unhelpful Thinking Patterns

Our minds are constantly interpreting what's happening around us. To do that quickly, the brain relies on familiar thinking patterns. Sometimes those patterns are helpful. Other times, they can distort how we read a situation and make a threat feel bigger or more certain than it actually is.



All-or-Nothing Thinking

Seeing things in extremes, perfect or a failure, with no middle ground.



Catastrophising

Taking a difficult moment and fast-forwarding to the worst possible outcome, then living there as if it's already happened.



Overgeneralising

Taking one painful experience and turning it into a permanent rule about how things always are.



Mental Filtering

Locking onto the one negative detail in a situation and letting it colour everything else, even when the evidence says otherwise.



Disqualifying the Positive

Acknowledging something good and then immediately finding a reason it doesn't count.



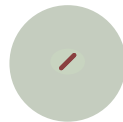
Mind Reading

Assuming you know what someone else is thinking, without any real evidence, and landing on the worst interpretation.



Fortune Telling

Predicting how something will go and treating that prediction as fact, before anything has actually happened.



Should Statements

Applying rigid rules to yourself or others about how things ought to be, and when reality doesn't match, the result is shame, guilt, or resentment.



Labelling

Taking a mistake or a moment and collapsing it into a fixed statement about who you fundamentally are.



Emotional Reasoning

Using how you feel as proof of how things actually are, if I feel it, it must be true.



Personalisation

Holding yourself responsible for things that were never really yours to carry.



Jumping to Conclusions

Skipping past the evidence and landing on a negative interpretation anyway, with total confidence and no real basis for it.

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Thinking Pattern	What It Sounds Like	What This Pattern Does
All-or-Nothing Thinking (Black-and-White Thinking)	<i>"I made one mistake. I've completely ruined it."</i> <i>"If I can't do it perfectly, there's no point trying."</i>	Keeps you stuck in a loop: think in extremes, feel terrible, pull back, repeat.
Catastrophising	<i>"I have a headache, what if something is really wrong with me?"</i> <i>"I embarrassed myself in that meeting. Everyone will think I'm incompetent."</i>	Inflates the threat and deflates your sense of being able to cope at the same time.
Overgeneralising	<i>"I can't ever get anything right."</i> <i>"Nobody ever really shows up for me."</i>	Quietly closes doors before you even try them.
Mental Filtering	<i>"My presentation went well but I stumbled once, the whole thing was a disaster."</i> <i>"They said I need to improve this one thing. They must think I'm terrible at this."</i>	One negative consistently outweighs ten positives.
Disqualifying the Positive	<i>"I did well but it was an easy task, anyone could have done it."</i> <i>"They're just saying that because they have to."</i>	If positive evidence gets cancelled every time it arrives, nothing can challenge what you believe about yourself.
Mind Reading	<i>"They went quiet, they're obviously annoyed at me."</i> <i>"My partner said they're fine but I know something is wrong and it's probably me."</i>	The read feels like intuition but it's usually your own fear and history talking.
Fortune Telling	<i>"There's no point going, I already know I won't enjoy it."</i> <i>"I already know they're going to say no so I won't even ask."</i>	The prediction shapes the behaviour, the behaviour shapes the outcome, the outcome confirms the prediction.
Should Statements	<i>"I should be over this by now."</i> <i>"They should know how I feel without me having to say it."</i>	Judgment doesn't motivate, it paralyses.
Labelling	<i>"I fell behind on that project. I suck at this."</i> <i>"That made me anxious. I'm just an anxious person."</i>	If the problem is who you are rather than what you did, there's nowhere to go.
Emotional Reasoning	<i>"I feel like a burden. I must be one."</i> <i>"I feel like nobody cares. They probably don't."</i>	If feeling something is proof it's true, no external evidence can challenge it.
Personalisation	<i>"They seem upset. I must have done something wrong."</i> <i>"They left. I must not have been enough."</i>	It makes you the cause of things that were never fully in your control.
Jumping to Conclusions	<i>"They didn't reply. They're obviously ignoring me."</i> <i>"She seemed off with me today. I must have done something."</i>	You're responding to a version of reality you constructed rather than the one that's actually there.